Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
  https://helix.wrwetzel.com
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
   Alt-u / – move backward / forward in tree history
     Alt-U
:ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by
              step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
 <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
       Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
        :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
       :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
   :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

  :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
  :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
        ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
              horizontal split
        ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
              vertical split
          gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url
              under selection.

         ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
         ␣F – open file picker at current working
              directory
         ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
    <enter> – open selected in current view
     Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
     Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
         :n – create new scratch buffer
        :bc – close current buffer
       :bca – close all buffers
       :bco – close all but current buffer
        :bn – next buffer
         ␣b – open buffer picker

        ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
        gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
        gn – go to next buffer
        gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and **␣w** are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
         ␣wq – close current split
         ␣wo – close all but current split
         ␣ww – next split

  ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down /
              right
         ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
          Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

     zz, zc – align to center
         zt – align to top
         zb – align to bottom
         zm – align to middle horizontally
         zj – scroll down
         zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
      h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
     gh, g| – beginning of line
     <nn>g| – column <nn>
         gl – end of line
         gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
         ge – bottom of file
         gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to
              word

         g.– to last modification in current file
         gj – down textual line
         gk – up textual line

         gs – first non-white-space char
         gt – top of screen
         gc – middle of screen
         gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
   % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at
        end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
    ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

        w / W – word / WORD
            p – paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
            m –  closest surround pair
            f – function
            t – type or class
            a – argument/parameter
            c – comment
            T – test
            g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
    w / W – to start of next word / WORD
    e / E – to end of current word / WORD
    b / B – to start of current word / WORD
        x – current line, extend by line
        X – extend to line
    Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
       ]p – to next paragraph
       [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
      v – toggle select mode
    Esc – return to normal
      ) – cycle primary selection forward
      ( – cycle primary selection backward
  Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
    s<regex> – matches become selections
           S – split on match
      Alt-s – split on newlines
  C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
           & – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
          , – remove all except primary selection
      Alt-, – remove primary selection
      ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
    Alt-( / – rotate content backward / forward
      Alt-)
           K – keep selections matching the regex
       Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
           i – before selection
           a – after selection
           I – at start of line
           A – at end of line
           o – add line and insert below cursor
           O – add line and insert above cursor
         Esc – end insert (return to normal)
           . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
          ]␣ – newline below
          [␣ – newline above
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
           d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
       Alt-d – delete, no save
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
           c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
       Alt-c – change, no save
           = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
           > – Indent line(s) containing selection
           < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
           ~ – change case
           ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
     Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
     Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
           J – join lines in a selection
       Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the
               inserted space
     <under> – trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
           y – selection -> yank buf
           p – paste yank buf after the cursor
           P – paste yank buf before the cursor
          ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
          ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
          ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
       r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
           R – replace selection with yank buf
           " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
   /<regex> – search forward for regex
   ?<regex> – search backward for regex
       n, N – next, previous match
          * – search for current selection, respect word
              boundaries
       Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
     "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
    "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
    "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
    "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
    ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
              mm – go to matching delim
        mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
        ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
        ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
        md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
   Alt-| – ignore output
      ! –  insert output before each selection(s)
   Alt-! –  append output after each selection(s)
      $ –  keep selection(s) where command
           returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
    ␣G – debug - experimental
    ␣k – show documentation for item under
         cursor
    ␣s – open document symbol picker
    ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
    ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
    ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
    ␣r – rename symbol
    ␣a – apply code action
    ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under
         cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
         :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config
                         file
       :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
    ␣' – open last picker
    ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder
         picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

Ctrl-s	commit undo checkpoint
Ctrl-x	autocomplete
Ctrl-r	insert a register content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Alt-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>	delete previous char
Ctrl-d, <del>	delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter>	insert new line
<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

Esc, Ctrl-c	close prompt
<enter>	open selected
<tab>	select next completion item
<backtab>	select previous completion item
Alt-b	backward a word
Ctrl-b	backward a char
Alt-f	forward a word
Ctrl-f	forward a char
Ctrl-e	to prompt end
Ctrl-a	to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h	delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d	delete next char
Ctrl-s	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p	select previous history
Ctrl-n	select next history
Ctrl-r	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>	previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>	next entry
<Home>	to first entry
<End>	to last entry
Ctrl-u, <PageUp>	page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown>	page down
<enter>	open selected
Alt-<enter>	open selected in the background without closing the picker
Ctrl-s	open horizontally
Ctrl-v	open vertically
Ctrl-t	toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

Ctrl-u	scroll up
Ctrl-d	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p	previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n	next entry
<enter>	close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c	close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

Alt-p	previous signature
Alt-n	next signature

4 Command Index

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(– specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
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Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor (2.3.1)
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Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree (2.2.3)
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Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node (2.3.4)
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Alt-s – split on newlines (2.5.1)
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history (2.1)
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C – add selection below, above (2.5.1)
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Ctrl-k – delete to end of line (3.2)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.3)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.5)
Ctrl-n – select next history (3.2)
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.3)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.5)
Ctrl-p – select previous history (3.2)
Ctrl-r – insert a register content (3.1)
Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by following input char (3.2)
Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint (3.1)
Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) (3.2)
Ctrl-s – open horizontally (3.3)
Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split (2.1.2.1)
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-t – toggle preview (3.3)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.1)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.2)
Ctrl-u – half page up (2.2.4)
Ctrl-u – page up (3.3)
Ctrl-u – scroll up (3.4)
Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split (2.1.2.1)
Ctrl-v – open vertically (3.3)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.1)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.2)
Ctrl-x – autocomplete (3.1)
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number (2.6.8)
Esc – close picker (3.3)
Esc – close prompt (3.2)
Esc – end insert (return to normal) (2.6.1)
Esc – return to normal (2.4)
Esc – return to normal mode (2.1)
F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
I – at start of line (2.6.1)
J – join lines in a selection (2.6.9)
K – keep selections matching the regex (2.5.2)
N – next, previous match (2.8)
O – add line and insert above cursor (2.6.1)
P – paste yank buf before the cursor (2.7)
R – replace selection with yank buf (2.7)
S – split on match (2.5.1)
Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char (3.1)
Shift-<tab> – previous entry (3.3)
Shift-Tab – previous entry (3.5)
T – test (2.3.2)
T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
Tab – next entry (3.5)
X – extend to line (2.3.3)
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc (2.1.4.1)
[␣ – newline above (2.6.2)
[– specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
[D – first diagnostic (2.2.2)
[G – to last, first change (2.2.3)
[T – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
[a – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
[c – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)
[d – prior diagnostic (2.2.2)
[f – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
[g – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
[p – to prior paragraph (2.3.3)
[t – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
]␣ – newline below (2.6.2)
]D – last diagnostic (2.2.2)
]G – to last, first change (2.2.3)
]T – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
]a – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
]c – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)

- **]d** – next diagnostic (2.2.2)
- **]f** – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
- **]g** – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
- **]p** – to next paragraph (2.3.3)
- **]t** – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
- **`** – set lowercase (2.6.6)
- **a** – after selection (2.6.1)
- **a** – argument/parameter (2.3.2)
- **b / B** – to start of current word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **c** – comment (2.3.2)
- **c** – selection -> yank buf, change selection (2.6.4)
- **d** – selection -> yank buf, delete selection (2.6.3)
- **e / E** – to end of current word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **etc.** – specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
- **f** – function (2.3.2)
- **f<ch>** – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
- **g** – change git hunk (2.3.2)
- **g.** – to last modification in current file (2.2.1)
- **g<nn>g** – line <nn> (2.2.1)
- **ga** – go to last accessed/alternate buffer (2.1.3)
- **gb** – bottom of screen (2.2.1)
- **gc** – middle of screen (2.2.1)
- **gd** – go to definition (2.2.2)
- **ge** – bottom of file (2.2.1)
- **gf** – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. (2.1.2)
- **gg** – top of file (2.2.1)
- **gh** – beginning of line (2.2.1)
- **gi** – go to implementation (2.2.2)
- **gj** – down textual line (2.2.1)
- **gk** – up textual line (2.2.1)
- **gl** – end of line (2.2.1)
- **gm** – go to last modified/alternate buffer (2.1.3)
- **gn** – go to next buffer (2.1.3)
- **gp** – go to previous buffer (2.1.3)
- **gr** – go to references (2.2.2)
- **gs** – first non-white-space char (2.2.1)
- **gt** – top of screen (2.2.1)
- **gw** – two-char labels on words, label to go to word (2.2.1)
- **gy** – go to type definition (2.2.2)
- **g|** – beginning of line (2.2.1)
- **h/j/k/l** – left / up / down / right (2.2.1)
- **i** – before selection (2.6.1)
- **m** – closest surround pair (2.3.2)
- **ma<ch>** – match around delim <ch> (2.12)
- **ma<ch> /** – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below: (2.3.2)
- **mi<ch>**
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection (2.12)
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection (2.6.3)
- **mi<ch>** – match inside delim <ch> (2.12)
- **mm** – go to matching delim (2.12)
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.12)
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.6.4)
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection (2.12)
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection (2.6.2)
- **n** – next, previous match (2.8)
- **o** – add line and insert below cursor (2.6.1)
- **p** – paragraph (2.3.2)
- **p** – paste yank buf after the cursor (2.7)
- **r<ch>** – replace selection with <ch> (2.7)
- **s<regex>** – matches become selections (2.5.1)
- **t** – type or class (2.3.2)
- **t<ch>** – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
- **u / U** – undo / redo change in linear history (2.1)
- **v** – toggle select mode (2.4)
- **w / W** – to start of next word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **w / W** – word / WORD (2.3.2)

- **x** – current line, extend by line (2.3.3)
- **y** – selection -> yank buf (2.7)
- **zb** – align to bottom (2.1.4.1)
- **zc** – align to center (2.1.4.1)
- **zj** – scroll down (2.1.4.1)
- **zk** – scroll up (2.1.4.1)
- **zm** – align to middle horizontally (2.1.4.1)
- **zt** – align to top (2.1.4.1)
- **zz** – align to center (2.1.4.1)
- **|** – replace selection(s) with output (2.13)
- **~** – change case (2.6.6)